

Editorial Writing

Invitational B Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School. From the given information, write an **editorial** as you would for the high school newspaper.

Remember that as an editorial writer, you should **support or oppose** policy or action; you should not sermonize. You have **45 minutes**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 4,820 students enrolled in grades 9-12. At December's school board meeting, Principal Christopher Yang proposed a new grading policy wherein students who fail a test or summative assignment will have no more than three days to make up the assignment, and students can only earn up to 70 on a retake. In addition, if a student does not turn in an assignment or misses a test, that student will have no more than three days to complete it. Previously, teachers could accept late work and allow students to retake tests at their own discretion. The school board agreed with Yang, and the new policy went into effect Jan. 6.

Leading up to the last week of fall semester, more than 50% of students were failing at least one class as a result of tests or assignments that had either not yet been made up or not yet been submitted, according to Yang. Teachers have complained that this lack of pressure on students to complete assignments on time has caused a back-up at the end of each grading period when students attempt to turn in missing assignments and retake tests.

Three students and their parents have started a petition against the new grading policy, saying each student learns at their own pace, and that it would be unfair to students to make such a drastic change to the grading policy in the middle of a school year. They plan to speak at the next board meeting to ask the district to incorporate more flexibility into the newly implemented retake policy to account for students who are in extracurricular activities or who may need additional time to study and complete assignments.

The school board will hear from the students and parents at its Feb. 19 meeting. You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed Feb. 16.

THOSE SUPPORTING THE POLICY

In the real world, people do not receive infinite chances to complete work. With no practice turning assignments in on time, students will not be prepared for college or real life. In addition, it is hard on teachers to set deadlines, only to have to grade each student's work when it's convenient for them to finally turn it in. Teachers need students to complete work and be successful on tests in a timely manner so they can move on to the next unit and complete the curriculum.

THOSE OPPOSING THE POLICY

Students do not all learn at exactly the same pace in exactly the same way. As long as students are learning, the district should be flexible on how or when that learning takes place. It is reasonable to put a limit on how long a student has to retake an assignment, but three days is nowhere near enough time for students to re-evaluate what they learned on an assignment and go back and try to be successful.

■ CHRISTOPHER YANG, principal

“We recognize that students don’t learn at the same pace. The idea for this policy is that everybody gets a second chance because that’s the way it is in real life. But those chances can’t extend forever and ever. At a certain point, we have to hold students accountable for what they’ve learned. Yes, students deserve opportunities to succeed, but it’s important that we set a high expectation so that students become more deliberate about the timeline in which they learn. We’re going to prepare them for the real world, where people get second chances, but those chances have a deadline.”

■ CHERYL DUTTON, chemistry teacher

“This policy helps students understand the impact of studying. I think that it will also create a better foundation on how to navigate the academic process, follow directions and stick to timelines. It’s more of a reflection of what they’ll see in college. Three days is completely fair. It gives the students a lot more pressure to initially get their grade fixed as quickly as possible.”

■ SWETA GAUTAM, sophomore

“Academically speaking, I don’t think the new policy is very smart. To only give three days to reteach and retake isn’t enough time. Let’s face it, some teachers are still learning the best way to teach certain units. Sometimes they’ll teach it, then we’ll take a test, and that teacher will realize that, unfortunately, they didn’t do a great job teaching this time. Students who are struggling have gotten used to having that additional time to study and review. I’m worried that the district will regret making this change when they see even more failures at the end of the year. This is why my parents and I helped create the petition to ask the district to reverse the new policy or at least add in some flexibility for teachers. Administrators should take their time to come up with a plan that will work. They should allow students to contribute their ideas and input, and they should wait until next year to implement the new policy.”

■ OLIVIA HACKETT, junior

“Some people are in extracurricular activities, which may prevent them from being able to go within the three days to make up tests or assignments. I’m worried this policy will encourage more people to cheat or use artificial intelligence to complete assignments because the school doesn’t care if assignments are done well. They just want them done fast.”

DO NOT PASS OUT TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST

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Editorial Writing Contest Tips and Sample Stories

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Lead with a statement of the situation and then take a clear, definitive staff stance. The situation is whether or not the district will reverse its new grading policy.
2. As a general rule, use third person. If you must use a pronoun, use first person plural (we, meaning "we, the newspaper staff"). Do not use first person singular (I, me, mine) or second person (you). Avoid unnecessary use of pronouns. Rather than "We believe the district should..." write instead, "The district should..."
3. Don't waddle into the editorial. Get right to the point and, as a general rule, don't ask questions. An editorial should answer questions, not ask them. Above all, remember that your purpose is to make thoughtful, logical arguments in support of your position, not to engage in a tirade. The editorial should not be long — 450 words at the most. Although it's not recommended all the time, sometimes a writer could use a feature opening to grab the reader's attention and draw them into the story.
4. Look for the future angle. This should be somewhere in your lead.
5. Once you've stated your position/stance, the body of the editorial should support your stance and refute the opposition.
6. After the body of your editorial, complete the editorial with a specific solution.
7. Avoid direct quotes. You can pull information from these quotes, as has been done here, but it's not necessary to attribute that information unless the person has substantial credibility.
8. Watch for factual errors. Pay attention to minor details. Also, stay focused.
9. Don't clutter up the editorial with clichés or trite phrases such as "adults don't understand teens" or any variation thereof. Also, edit out the name of the school unless it is necessary for clarity. It isn't necessary to say "Leaguetown Independent School District" or "Leaguetown High School." Students know the name of the school. They don't need to be reminded.

SAMPLE EDITORIAL/SUPPORTING THE POLICY

At the December school board meeting, Principal Christopher Yang proposed a new grading policy that would allow students to retake assignments and turn in late work after no more than three days. In addition, students who retake a failed test can only make up to a 70. The school board passed the new policy, but a group of concerned students and parents will ask the board to reverse its decision at its Feb. 19 meeting.

The school board should stick with its new policy.

Under the old policy, it was too easy for students to take advantage of the system and turn all their work in at the end of the grading period. This does not give them any incentive to meet deadlines or do well on assignments in the first attempt. Now, students will be willing to put in the extra work to study for their original tests because the highest score on a retake is barely passing.

This policy prepares students for their futures. In college and in the work force, deadlines are strict. Students need to be ready to meet due dates if they want to be successful. The previous grading system was too lenient and did not properly represent how real life is.

Those who oppose the new grading system believe it does not take into account the fact that students all learn at different paces. While this is true, it is the responsibility of the student to get help, so they can understand course work in a timely manner. The school offers resources to accommodate students who need extra help.

Finally, the new policy makes teachers' jobs easier. The previous grading system overworked teachers at the end of each term by forcing them to grade dozens of overdue assignments. This new system allows teachers to grade in a timely manner and not be rushed at the end of each grading period, not to mention the added stress of having to beg students to submit old assignments before the grading period ends.

This decision should stand, and like the policy, there should not be an extended deadline. The new grading policy will ease teachers' workload, hold students accountable and prepare students for the real world.

SAMPLE EDITORIAL/OPPOSING THE POLICY

At the December school board meeting, Principal Christopher Yang proposed a new grading policy that would allow students to retake assignments and turn in late work after no more than three days. In addition, students who retake a failed test can only make up to a 70. The school board passed the new policy, but a group of students and parents will ask the board to reverse its decision at its Feb. 19 meeting.

The school board should reverse course and remove the new grading policy.

This new grading policy could result in an increase in students cheating on assignments. Instead of taking the time to study and learn material they miss, students could turn to cheating, overuse of artificial intelligence and copying work from their peers because they are stressed by the three-day deadline. This causes a lack of learning and could result in students doing worse on standardized tests because they do not learn the material. Instead, they rush to get a good grade and meet deadlines.

In addition to cheating, this policy could result in students turning in subpar work. Students are not used to these shorter deadlines, and that could lead to rushed and sloppy work. If too many students are scoring low because of this new grading system, it would reflect poorly on the district.

Those in support of the new grading system believe it prepares students for the real world. But there are exceptions and circumstances that allow deadlines to be shifted in any situation. The new policy is too strict and unrealistic for students.

This policy does not allow for exceptions for emergencies or special circumstances. If a student is in the hospital or has a family emergency, the new policy does not mention an exception or extension for them. If students are highly involved in clubs, athletics or extracurricular activities, they may not have enough time to retake or make up assignments within the three-day limit. Students with these extra responsibilities will have a tough time adhering to this policy.

Parents and staff should encourage the school board to rethink this policy. The new grading policy could cause students to submit lazy work and cheat their way through school. It creates unrealistic expectations for students who have other things going on outside of academic classes.